Through a Parkdale Lens: Newcomer Families' Access to and Use of Child Care Support Resources in Toronto: Methodology

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Research Methodology

I will use a qualitative methodology to explore how newcomer families at one Toronto child care centre learn about, understand, and use or do not use the family support resources that the centre offers or refers families to, which in this study means services such as the City of Toronto child care fee subsidy, EarlyON, and settlement services. Qualitative research studies a small number of participants in depth, so that the researcher can gather detailed accounts of one central phenomenon (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). My central question asks how newcomer families describe their experiences of accessing and using or not using these resources, and a question of this kind calls for depth. Between first hearing about a resource and using it, a family may read a notice, ask an educator, or give up on a form that seems too hard. Application counts would record only the outcome. They would leave out what a parent understood, who offered help, and where the process stopped. Those details sit at the centre of my question, and open conversations are more likely to draw them out.

Context is the second reason for this choice. Creswell and Guetterman (2019) note that qualitative researchers attend closely to the context shaping participants' experiences. Here, context means the way the centre shares information about resources, the languages that information appears in, the referrals staff make, and the documents each application requires. Not every family meets these conditions in the same way, since languages and migration journeys differ, so the families' accounts will be read alongside a description of them. Parents can describe such context from anywhere. A Zoom or phone interview therefore remains a workable option, although it carries fewer non-verbal cues than meeting face to face. To offset this, parents will be asked to walk me through particular moments, like the first notice they read or the evening they sat down with an application form.

The third reason is meaning-making. Mwita (2022) describes qualitative research as grounded in constructivism and concerned with how people make meaning of their social realities. That concern

fits this study. Research and service planning often leave newcomer parents' perspectives out, and words such as eligibility or waitlist can carry one meaning for a parent and a different one for an educator. A family's reading of this information then shapes whether a resource gets used. Through open-ended questions, I can hear how each family interprets eligibility rules and educators' explanations and how it arrives at a decision. Where families read the same rules differently, those differences add depth to the data.

Research Design

I will use a qualitative descriptive design, which aims to give a full summary of events in the everyday language of the people who experienced them (Sandelowski, 2000). Researchers who use it stay close to what participants say, keeping interpretation low, so the findings reflect participants' own words more than the researcher's. The design also studies experiences in their natural setting, without variables or a theory chosen in advance (Hall & Liebenberg, 2024).

This design fits my study for three reasons. First, qualitative description reports events in the words of the people who lived them (Sandelowski, 2000). That feature shapes my interview protocol, which will follow the steps a family takes with a resource, from hearing about it, to working out what it requires, to deciding whether to use it. My sub-questions are practical ones about what helped or limited families, who explained the steps, and how educators responded to language and cultural needs. With the analysis kept close to parents' words, the findings can be laid out along the same steps, so each part answers one of these questions. Second, qualitative description suits studies that need information directly from the people affected but have limited time and resources (Hall & Liebenberg, 2024), and a single-centre student project, completed within one term, fits that description. Third, practice can benefit from findings that remain close to participants' words (Villamin et al., 2025). Educators at the centre could use them to see where their explanations and referrals help families, and where they fall short. Ilumin (2023) used the same design, with immigrant families in Edmonton, to describe their child care experiences.

Participants, Recruitment and Sampling Plan

Participants and Recruitment

Participants

The participants will be four newcomer parents or primary caregivers. I define a newcomer family as an immigrant or refugee family with young children that has lived in Canada for five years or less (Massing et al., 2024). Each participant must (a) be 18 or older, (b) have arrived in Canada within the past five years, in any immigration category, (c) have a child enrolled at the study centre, (d) have received information about, or a referral to, at least one family support service from the centre in the past 12 months, such as the City of Toronto child care fee subsidy, EarlyON, or settlement services, and (e) be able to take part in English or Mandarin, or with an interpreter.

These criteria select parents with direct and recent experience with accessing and utilizing the resources my questions ask about. Criterion (d) includes parents whether or not they went on to use the resource, because my research question asks about both using and not using resources. I will explore each family's account on its own terms. The study will not divide families into users and non-users, and it will not compare them.

I will exclude families I have worked with in the past, including families from the room where I completed my placement, and families of centre staff. My earlier role, or a parent's employment at the centre, could make these families feel obliged to take part or less willing to speak critically about the centre (Villamin et al., 2025). Because I define newcomers by their time in Canada, eligibility will not depend on immigration category. Permanent residents, refugees and refugee claimants, parents with work or study permits, and parents who became citizens within the past five years will all be eligible, because immigration status can affect eligibility for services such as the fee subsidy, for example through tax-filing requirements (Toronto Children's Services, 2025), and these differences are part of what families experience. I will also not ask about immigration status. Fee subsidy applications require tax documents that undocumented families often cannot provide (Schmidt, 2026), and questions about status could discourage families from joining.

Recruitment Setting

Recruitment will take place at a licensed child care centre in the Parkdale neighbourhood of west Toronto, the centre where I completed my field placement, and to protect families' privacy, I will not name it in the proposal or in any later report. Two reasons led me to this setting. One is that the centre already offers and refers family support resources, so its families have lived the experiences

my questions ask about. Toronto's service plan also treats child care settings as access points and lists tax-filing requirements among the barriers to fee subsidy (Toronto Children's Services, 2025), which means a single centre can reveal how city policy reaches families. The other reason is practical, since my placement gives me access to the centre and makes recruitment feasible within the course timeline.

Recruitment Methods

No family will be contacted until two approvals are in place, one from the George Brown Polytechnic Research Ethics Board (Canadian Institutes of Health Research et al., 2022) and one, in writing, from the centre director. A one-page flyer and a letter of information will then be prepared in plain English and translated into Mandarin and the other languages common at the centre. Parents reading them will learn the purpose of the study, the time involved, about 60 to 75 minutes in a single meeting, that taking part is voluntary, that a $25 gift card is offered, and how to reach me. The card is a way of recognizing the time each parent gives. Under TCPS 2, researchers must consider participants' economic circumstances so that an incentive does not turn into an undue inducement (Canadian Institutes of Health Research et al., 2022). Head (2009) makes a similar point, observing that payment in qualitative research can honour participants' time but may also affect consent. For this reason I chose a modest amount, and the card will not depend on completing the interview, since parents who skip questions, or stop early, will still receive it. The Research Ethics Board will also review the amount before recruitment begins.

Invitations will go out through the parent newsletter, the notice board, and family cubbies, and no staff member will approach a family in person. Following Hardware et al. (2026), the invitation will be distributed by someone other than the lead researcher, which avoids a conflict of interest. Still, a notice from the director could feel like a request from the centre, so the flyer will state that the centre will not know who takes part, and that the decision will not affect any child's care. Parents who are interested can reach me directly by email, phone, or text, and their eligibility will be confirmed in a 10-minute call. Parents will have at least 48 hours to decide after they receive the consent form. If fewer than four parents respond by the middle of Week 1, the director will send one reminder.

Sampling Plan

Sampling Strategy. Purposive sampling, in which the researcher deliberately chooses people who can help explain the central phenomenon (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019), will guide who is invited. In this study those people are newcomer parents who have been given information about, or a referral to, a family support service by the centre. Recruitment will also rely on convenience, drawing on willing and available parents at a centre I can already reach (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). Put simply, the criteria settle who is eligible, and convenience settles where they are found. Neither approach is meant to represent all newcomer families. What they offer instead is access to parents who can describe, in detail, how they accessed and used resources through this centre.

Participant Selection. Contact will come from parents themselves. In the 10-minute eligibility call, each parent will be screened against the inclusion and exclusion criteria, and the centre will have no role in screening or selection, nor will it learn who responded. Before deciding, eligible parents will receive the letter of information and the consent form in their preferred language. The first four eligible parents who agree will make up the sample, one adult per family. Anyone else who qualifies will be offered a place on a waitlist, in order of contact, and invited if a participant withdraws before the interview.

Sample Size. Four participants will take part, the number required for individual projects in this course. According to Creswell and Guetterman (2019), qualitative studies commonly involve about four to eight participants, a range small enough to explore each person’s experience in detail. My findings will therefore describe four families’ experiences, without generalizing them to all newcomer families.

Data Collection

Procedure

Individual, semi-structured, in-depth interviews will be my data collection method. The tool for these interviews is an interview protocol. It will list open-ended questions with follow-up probes, and because the order can shift, I can follow up whenever a parent brings up something new. Focus groups would suit this study less well than individual interviews. Income and subsidy are sensitive topics, and families at one centre may know one another (Villamin et al., 2025). Before Week 1, the

protocol will be piloted with one newcomer parent from outside the study, to check its wording, translation, and length.

A single meeting of about 60 to 75 minutes is planned for each participant, scheduled at a time the family chooses. The meeting can happen in a private room at the centre outside drop-off and pick-up times, or on Zoom or by phone. Online participants may turn off the camera and use a pseudonym, as in Hardware et al. (2026). Mandarin speakers will be interviewed by me directly. When another language is needed, a trained interpreter who has signed a confidentiality agreement will join, so that meaning is not lost in translation (Ilumin, 2023). Each meeting will follow three steps:

1. **Consent (about 10 minutes).** I will go through the letter of information with the parent, in their language, and answer any questions, after which the parent will sign the consent form or give recorded verbal consent.
2. **Background form (about 5 minutes).** On this short form, the parent will note years in Canada, children's ages, home language, and the services the centre shared information about or referred them to, but not immigration status or income.
3. **Interview (45 to 60 minutes).** With permission, I will audio record the interview, and the questions will follow the steps families take toward a resource. Parents will describe how they learned about a resource, what they understood about eligibility and applying, and who helped them, whether educators, settlement workers, or relatives, as well as what that help involved. They will then talk about what led them to use or not use the resource. Finally, I will ask whether they could raise needs linked to their language and culture, how educators responded, and what they would suggest the centre change. At the end, each parent will receive the $25 gift card, along with a list of community supports such as EarlyON and 211 Toronto.

Taking part is voluntary. Parents may skip any question, or stop the interview at any time, and will still receive the gift card, and they may withdraw their data within one week after their interview, before I begin coding it, without any effect on their child's care. I will remove names, use pseudonyms, and keep recordings and transcripts in encrypted, password-protected files stored apart

from the consent forms, with only me holding the list that links pseudonyms to names. Because a small sample from one centre can make people identifiable, my reports will not combine details such as country of origin and home language, and I will change or leave out any quotation that could identify a family (Villamin et al., 2025).

Timeline of Research Study

Table 1

Timeline of the Research Study

Period	Research activity	Main tasks
By December 2026	Ethics and preparation	Obtain ethics approval and the director's permission, translate materials, and pilot the interview protocol
Weeks 1 and 2	Recruit participants	Director circulates the invitation, with one reminder if needed. I screen callers, obtain consent, and book interviews
Weeks 2 and 3	Collect data	Interviews start in Week 2. At least three of four (75%) are done by the end of Week 3, each transcribed soon after
Week 4	Complete data collection	Fourth interview held. Initial coding starts
Week 5	Preliminary findings	Preliminary findings summary due
Weeks 6 and 7	Complete analysis	Semantic-level thematic analysis finished (Braun & Clarke, 2022), with the findings report submitted by Week 7
Weeks 8 and 9	Refine findings	Feedback used to review and refine the findings
Week 10	Presentation draft	Draft of the presentation ready
Weeks 11 to 13	Revise	Revisions to the presentation and the final report
Week 14	Final submission	Final report handed in

Recruitment starts in Week 1 and the first interviews follow in Week 2, so ethics approval has to be granted before the term begins. Transcribing each interview soon after it ends means coding can start in Week 4, with preliminary findings ready for Week 5. Decisions, changes, and challenges will go into my reflexive journal as they happen.

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